

Net Zero, Energy Bills and Green Backlash

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THE LONDON SCHOOL
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Climate Change and the Populist Right



Figure: Reform UK Leaflet (2025 UK local elections)

- **Core question:** Can populist radical right (PRR) parties turn uneven household energy costs into political gains by framing them as evidence that Net Zero is unfair and costly?

Theoretical Background

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- **Third mechanism:** Crisis-to-ownership framing
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■ **Third mechanism:** Crisis-to-ownership framing

1. PRR parties convert diffuse shocks into focused claims on issues they 'own'
2. What matters is not whether climate policy *caused* higher prices, but whether voters were convinced by PRR framing

Crisis-to-Ownership Framing

1. **Supply side (PRR messaging).** PRR parties connect the uneven consequences of the crisis to an issue on which they are widely seen as competent
 - 1.1 *PRR parties connect energy bills to Net Zero, which they reject in full*

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3. **Mechanism (blame attribution).** Voters that are more exposed adopt the same blame attribution stance articulated by PRR parties
 - 3.1 *Voters in more exposed areas become more likely to say environmental protections have “gone too far,” without parallel shifts in broad economic assessments.*

Data

- **PRR messaging (supply):** UKIP press releases; UKIP & Reform UK YouTube transcripts (2021–2025). Text windows coded for (bills) & (Net Zero) & causal connectors.
- **Exposure (pre-shock):** Energy Performance Certificates (EPCs) ~27M records; mean EPC at LSOA (<2021) as vulnerability index.
- **Outcomes (demand):** *Understanding Society* panel (vote intention for UKIP/Reform/Brexit Party); BES internet panel (attitudes).

See paper for further details.

Designs

1) Text analysis (supply): Share of short transcript windows with bills + Net Zero + causal/blame connectors; three strictness levels; aligned to price/campaign moments.

2) Difference-in-Differences (DiD):

$$y_{it} = \alpha_i + \gamma_t + \beta(\text{EPC}_{\text{LSOA}} \times \text{Post}_t) + X'_{it}\theta + \varepsilon_{it}$$

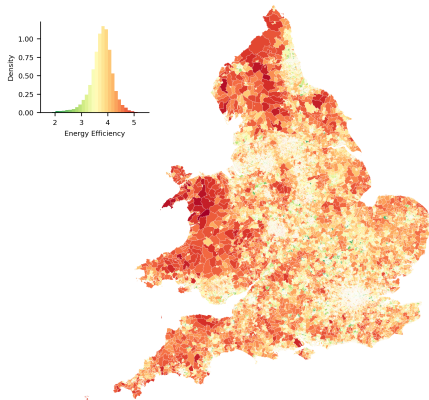
with individual & year FE; rich local controls.

3) Event study: Year-specific EPC interactions to check pre-trends.

4) Triple-Differences (DDD): $\text{EPC} \times \text{GasDep} \times \text{Post}$ to test amplification via gas heating.

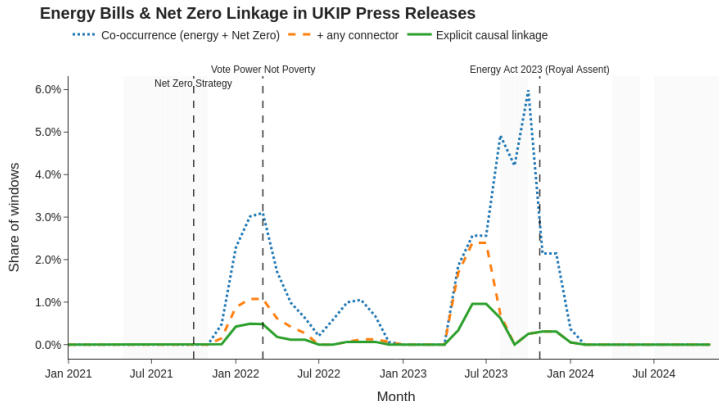
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Neighborhood Energy Price Vulnerability



Source: <2021 EPCs & 2021 ONS LSOA boundaries

PRR Parties Blame Net Zero for Higher Energy Bills



Energy Price Vulnerability → Increased Support for PRR Parties

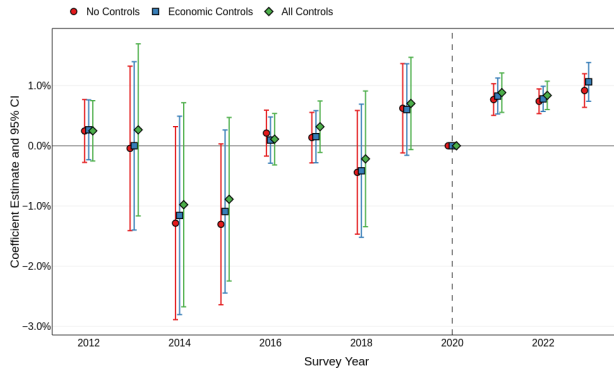


Figure: DV: Vote Intention for PRR Party

Amplification & Robustness

Triple-Differences (DDD). $EPC \times Gas \times Post$ positive: gas-heated households in inefficient areas show ~ 1 pp larger PRR shift than non-gas counterparts.

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- Reported gas spending: negligible pre-differences; rises after the shock in inefficient areas (design captures bill exposure).
- Income placebo: EPC vulnerability does not predict changes in household income (rules out income channel).

Mechanism & Interpretation

■ Results thus far in line with theories of retrospective voting

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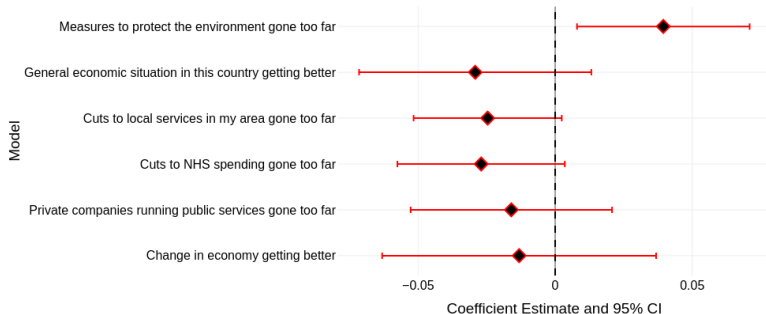
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Mechanism & Interpretation

- Results thus far in line with theories of retrospective voting
- In more exposed places, respondents become more likely to say environmental protections have *gone too far*.
- No comparable movement in general economic evaluations.

Read: Policy-specific blame attribution consistent with the affordability frame rather than broad economic malaise.

Energy Price Vulnerability → Shifting Environmental Attitudes

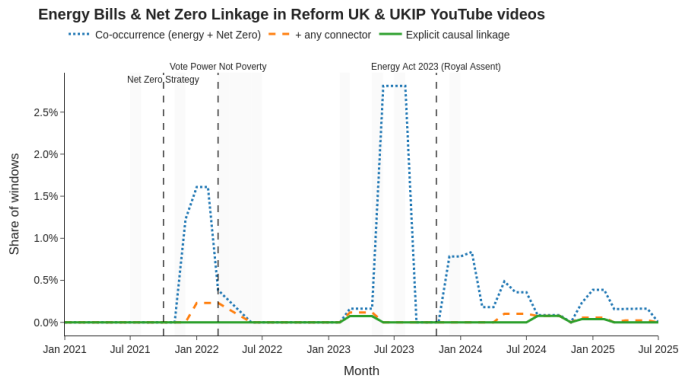


Takeaways

1. PRR actors *explicitly* linked bills to Net Zero at cost spikes (supply).
2. Voters in more exposed (inefficient, gas-heated) areas shifted toward PRR (demand).
3. Attitudinal change is *climate-specific*, not generic economic pessimism.

Policy lesson: Design the transition to minimize salient, uneven household burdens—and communicate that design.

Results I: PRR Blame Linkage (Supply) - YouTube



Robustness - Reported Energy Bills

